

# Python Course: Pre-Arrival Setup

Welcome! To ensure we can dive straight into coding on the first day, please follow these instructions to install the necessary tools. **Please complete these steps before the course begins.**

**⚠ CRITICAL FOR WINDOWS USERS:** During the Python installation process, you **MUST** check the box that says "Add Python to PATH" at the bottom of the first screen. This ensures your computer can find Python when you type commands.

## Step 1: Install Python

Python is the programming language engine. Follow these specific steps to get the correct version:

### Windows Instructions

1. Visit [www.python.org](https://www.python.org).
2. Hover over the **Downloads** button in the main navigation banner.
3. From the menu that appears, click **Windows**.
4. Scroll down to the section titled "**Stable Releases**".
5. Under the latest Python 3 release (e.g., Python 3.12.x), click **Windows installer (64-bit)**.
6. Run the downloaded `.exe` file.
7. **Mandatory:** Tick the box "Add Python to PATH" before clicking **Install Now**.

## macOS Instructions

1. Visit [www.python.org](https://www.python.org).
2. Hover over **Downloads** in the main banner and click **macOS**.
3. Under "**Stable Releases**", find the latest Python 3 release.
4. Click on **macOS 64-bit universal2 installer**.
5. Open the `.pkg` file and follow the standard installation prompts.

## Step 2: Install VS Code

Visual Studio Code is our code editor. Visit [code.visualstudio.com](https://code.visualstudio.com). Click the large **Download** button for your operating system and run the installer, accepting all default settings.

## Step 3: Verification (The Terminal)

Confirm your setup is ready by testing the internal terminal in VS Code:

- **How to open:** Click the **Terminal** menu at the very top of the VS Code window and select **New Terminal**.
- **UK Keyboard Shortcut:** Alternatively, press `Ctrl + '`  (the Apostrophe key).
- **The Command:** In the black window that appears at the bottom, type `python --version` and press **Enter**.
- **Success:** It should display a version number (e.g., `Python 3.12.3` ).

